rather than the people. At the same time, active elected ethnic representations from the Rakhine, Mon, Shan, Chin and Kachin States made their presence felt (Farrelly 2014).

The next phase of political reconfiguration followed the by-election held on 1 April 2012. By this stage, the National League for Democracy had agreed to participate in politics under the 2008 Constitution. Aung San Suu Kyi and forty members of her NLD team were elected to the Union Assembly. While they remained a modest force in Naypyitaw, the NLD could get familiar with how the system worked from the inside. Under these conditions, Aung San Suu Kyi had regular opportunities to interact with senior members of the USDP, particularly the speakers of the Union Assembly, Shwe Mann, and Khin Aung Myint. As retired senior military officers and loyal servants of the SPDC regime, they welcomed her presence in the legislature. The NLD representatives tended to keep quiet, only occasionally attacking government policies or querying the direction of the reform process. Their lack of law-making experience was telling even among an almost entirely novice contingent of USDP legislators.

After much waiting, and while there was some doubt about the potential for a free and fair vote, the 2015 general election offered the Myanmar people a chance to have their say. At the ballot box, voters rushed to endorse NLD candidates even though most were not well-known figures. This trend carried into ethnic areas where narrowly focused ethnic political advocates struggled to receive enough votes to win in the unforgiving first-past-the-post system. This result also revealed the changing demographics of many ethnic regions. They have become genuinely multi-ethnic, especially in urban townships that have drawn migrants from across the country. For now, the hard electoral mathematics seems to favour those parties that can create a genuinely national story of inclusion and change.

But the NLD's strong election result does not imply that political contention has disappeared. Religious politics remains a specific concern, especially among Buddhist communities anxious about the direction of social change. For now, no Muslims sit in the legislatures or hold any senior government positions. Other political interests that are not well represented in the new political system include young people, women, LGBTI communities, and the peasant and labouring classes. Politics in Myanmar remains an elite activity, where Aung San Suu Kyi, the daughter of the country's independence hero, exemplifies the distance between most voters and the politicians who take their seats in Naypyitaw: her comfort